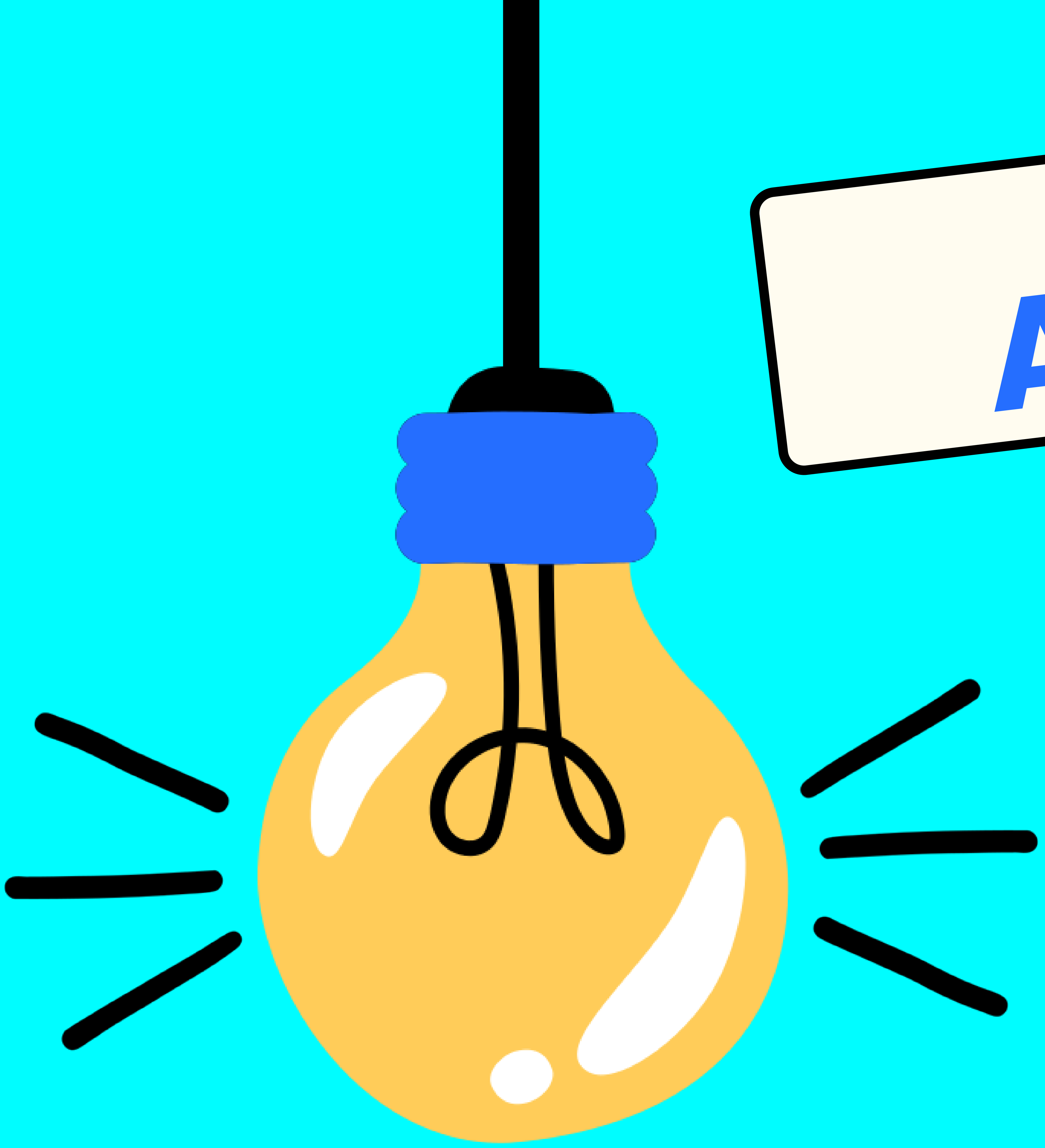
FINOPS FOR PLATFORM TEAMS

Cost Accountability Without the Drama

Kunal Das · Developer Advocate, CAST AI
FossAsia Summit 2026 · Bangkok



AGENDA

1. The Scenario
2. The Problem
3. The Landscape
4. The Playbook & Future

IMAGINE THIS...

It's the last Monday of the month. Your CTO forwards the cloud bill to Slack. **It's 40% higher than last month.**

Finance wants answers by EOD. Engineering says nothing changed. Your platform team is stuck in the middle, pasting numbers between AWS Cost Explorer and a spreadsheet nobody trusts.

Three hours later: a rough answer. Nobody's happy.

WHAT'S GOING WRONG?

1. No Cost Attribution — Resources aren't tagged. Nobody knows who spent what.

2. Reactive, Not Proactive — Teams only look at costs when the bill arrives.

3. Different Languages — Eng thinks in pods. Finance thinks in cost centers.

"It's like getting a restaurant bill for the whole table with no itemization."

THE NUMBERS

90%

of cluster resources sit idle — we over-provision because we fear outages

32%

of organizations have any K8s cost attribution

DON'T LIE

3-8x

average memory over-request by engineering teams

This isn't a tooling problem. It's an accountability problem.

THE INDUSTRY

FinOps Foundation: Inform › Optimize › Operate cycle

Enterprise tools: Kubecost, CloudHealth, Apptio — expensive & complex

Open Source: OpenCost is now CNCF Incubating

"5 years ago you needed Datadog. Today Prometheus handles it. Same shift for cost."

FinOps Foundation

kubecost

OpenCost

CAST AI

OUR TOOLKIT

OpenCost — Cost Allocation Engine

Grafana — Dashboards & Alerts

Prometheus — Metrics Storage

OPA Gatekeeper — Policy Enforcement

STEP 1

Label Everything

(But Start Small)

team | environment | project

deployment.yaml

```yaml
metadata:
  labels:
    team: backend-payments
    cost-center: CC-4200
    environment: production
    project: checkout-api
```

Enforce with OPA Gatekeeper

No label, no deploy.

Reject any deployment missing required cost labels.

Labels are like itemizing the restaurant bill — once every dish has a name next to it, the arguments stop.

STEP 2

Dashboards Teams Actually Check

Show costs per team, not per node

Engineers relate to team namespaces, not EC2 instance IDs.

Update daily, not quarterly

Stale data kills trust. Fresh data drives action.

Put it where engineers already look

Grafana, not a separate FinOps portal nobody visits.

Concept: Showback
Show costs without charging. Build awareness before accountability.

`Pre-built dashboards available via opencost-mixin`

STEP 3

Alerts That Don't Create Drama

The Drama Way

Alert: "Cloud bill exceeded $50k"

Sent to: Everyone

When: It's already too late

Result: *Panic & finger-pointing*

Smoke detector *vs finding out from the* ***insurance company.***

The No-Drama Way

Alert: "payments trending 20% above budget"

Sent to: Payments team lead

When: While there's still time to act

Result: *Informed trade-off decisions*

```
sum(opencost_container_cost_cpu_hourly_total{namespace="payments"}) > 200
```

STEP 4

Talk to Finance (Without Spreadsheet Wars)

1 Translate

Map K8s namespaces to cost centers finance already uses. Speak their language, not yours.

payments-ns → CC-4200 Payments

2 Visualize

Replace the monthly spreadsheet war with live Grafana dashboards. Invite finance to look.

"Can I get a link to that dashboard?"

3 Align

Start with showback. Chargeback comes later — when everyone trusts the data.

Showback first → Trust → Chargeback

Goal: *Finance and engineering looking at the same screen — not arguing over different spreadsheets.*

GOING FORWARD

Your Maturity Path

CRAWL

Week 1

- Install OpenCost (one Helm cmd)
- See cluster-level costs
- Get shocked by idle spend

WALK

Month 1

- Add team + env labels
- Build Grafana showback dashboard
- Share in sprint reviews

RUN

Quarter 1

- Enforce labeling via OPA
- Set namespace budget alerts
- Start chargeback conversations

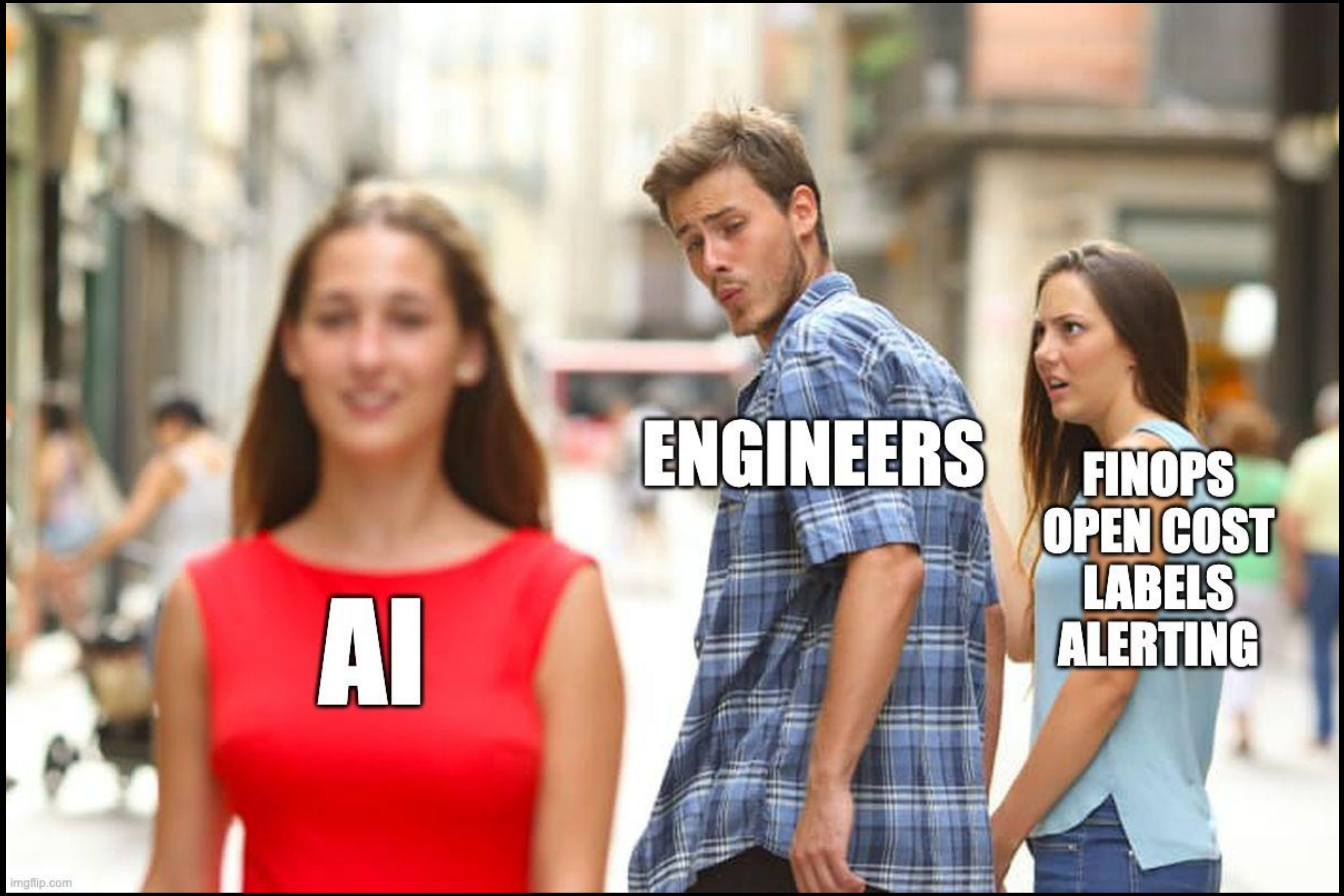
FLY

Beyond

- AI-driven cost queries (MCP)
- Automated right-sizing
- Full FinOps automation

Start small. Ship visibility. Iterate. No need to boil the ocean.

No slide is complete without saying



THE FUTURE

FinOps Meets AI

OpenCost MCP Agent

You: Which namespace overspent last week?

AI: payments exceeded budget by 18% ($760 over).
Top contributor: checkout-api pod scaling at 2am UTC.

You: Right-size it and set an alert at $3k.

AI is acting ...

MCP Server

AI agents query cost data in natural language. Ships with OpenCost.

Anomaly Detection

AI catches cost spikes before humans notice. Proactive, not reactive.

Automated Right-Sizing

Recommendations based on actual usage. From suggestion to auto-action.

The future: *from dashboards you check → to agents that* ***inform you proactively.***

QUICK RECAP

The No-Drama Playbook

1 Label Everything

3 labels: team, environment, project

`OPA Gatekeeper enforces it`

2 Dashboards Teams Check

Showback in Grafana, not spreadsheets

`opencost-mixin for pre-built views`

3 Alerts Without Drama

Namespace-level, to the right person

`Prometheus + AlertManager → Slack`

4 Talk to Finance

Translate, visualize, align

`Showback first → Trust → Chargeback`

Open source tools you already run. No drama required. Start Monday.

THANK YOU!

Kunal Das

Developer Advocate, CAST AI

FossAsia Summit 2026 · Bangkok

RESOURCES

Core Tools (the stack from the talk)

opencost.io — OpenCost docs, install guide, API reference
opencost.io/docs/integrations — OpenCost + Prometheus + Grafana setup
github.com/opencost/opencost — Source code, issues, MCP server docs
prometheus.io/docs — Prometheus alerting rules reference
grafana.com/grafana/dashboards — Community dashboard library

Ready-to-Use Templates

github.com/opencost/opencost-mixin — Pre-built Grafana dashboards for OpenCost
github.com/open-policy-agent/gatekeeper-library — OPA Gatekeeper policy templates (for label enforcement)

FinOps Knowledge

finops.org — FinOps Foundation framework, Inform→Optimize→Operate
finops.org/framework/capabilities/cost-allocation — Cost allocation best practices
focus.finops.org — FOCUS spec (open standard for cloud billing data)

CNCF / Community

cncf.io/projects/opencost — OpenCost's CNCF Incubating project page
kubernetes.io/docs/concepts/overview/working-with-objects/labels — K8s labeling best practices